

« Ashwin *bhai* approaches his strategies like a chess Grandmaster »

K. C. Cariappa

Ashwin *bhai* is a legend, and since my early days, I have closely followed his journey, particularly because he was one of the first in India to bowl the carrom ball. As someone who bowls the carrom ball frequently, I have always taken inspiration from him. A couple of years ago, I finally had the opportunity to share the dressing room with him at Rajasthan Royals. Those two seasons were a tremendous learning experience for me.

I interacted with him extensively about how he sets up batters and formulates his strategies. Every time, he patiently listened and guided me on how to improve my game.

He emphasised the importance of having my own plans while bowling my quota of overs and made me realise that while execution may not always go as planned, the preparation and strategy must be flawless. I took his advice to heart and tried implementing it whenever I got the chance to bowl.

While Yuzvendra Chahal is known for being a chess master, I have always believed that Ashwin *bhai* approaches his strategies

like a chess Grandmaster, constantly putting the batter in a spot of bother. Watching Ashwin *bhai* and Yuzi *bhai* prepare in the nets was fascinating — they strategised as though they were playing chess, always thinking several moves ahead and challenging the batter. Those practice sessions were incredibly insightful.

I still remember the first time I bowled to him in a practice match ahead of the 2022 IPL season.

After the match, I asked him what he had been planning while facing me.

He gave me his honest feedback and also told me that, as a bowler, it is crucial to have a Plan B and to keep the

batter under pressure.

Those conversations with him were invaluable and significantly contributed to my learning curve.

As told to Shayan Acharya



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